GFH1000 In Dialogue with Humanity

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Boundless Love and Salvation

The actions and sayings of Jesus in *Mark* chapters 2-7 different from the old tradition represented by Pharisees and Scribes and I'm going to explain why he did so. And by comparing him with the deeds of Krishna in the *Bhagavad Gita* which I found them in great similarity, I aim to get a better understanding to the core theme of *Bible* regarding the unconditional love and the path to salvation.

Firstly, Jesus heals a paralyzed man and forgives his sins, which astonishes the crowd and angers the Scribes who accuse Him of blasphemy (*Mark* 2:1-12), as they assume only God can forgive sins and a mortal cannot play God's role in saving people. This act not only highlighted Jesus' divine identity and compassion but also marks the beginning of his subsequent challenges to the established traditional Jewish religious beliefs. Although Jesus continuously saves people afterward, this is his first public act of forgiveness and healing, making it of great significance in Mark's Gospel.

Then, in the Levis' home, Jesus dines with tax collectors and sinners. This is criticized by the Pharisees, because they considered tax collectors and sinners unclean,
to maintain their ritual purity and social status they often avoid dining with the "uncleans". But Jesus responds that he "came to call sinners, not the righteous" (*Mark* 2:13-17). This marks his mission is to save those who are lost and marginalized. Revealing that everyone has a chance to be saved, rather than only those who hold high social status.

Also, Jesus challenges the Pharisees' strict Sabbath rules by allowing his disciples to pick grain and by healing a man with a withered hand on the Sabbath, emphasized that the

Sabbath was made for man, not man for the Sabbath (*Mark* 2:23-28; 3:1-6). Those people picked grains because they were hungry and needed food. Additionally, in *Mark* 7:1-9, Jesus criticizes the Pharisees for prioritizing ritual purity, as they condemned his disciples for eating with unwashed hands. Jesus highlights that it is not the external actions but the internal purity and the faith in the divine that matter. So, Jesus prioritized human well-being over rigid laws, demonstrating that mercy is a theme of his teaching.

Lastly, Jesus performs miracles such as calming a storm (*Mark* 4:35-41), casting out demons (*Mark* 5:1-20), and raising Jairus' daughter from the dead (*Mark* 5:21-43), showcasing his authority over nature, evil, and death, which greatly shocked the Pharisees and Scribes because they often attributed the power over nature directly to God rather than an individual claiming to be divine. However, these actions signified a new understanding of divine authority. Jesus performs miracles with humility and compassion. His purpose was not to show off how powerful he is, but to encourage people to develop a personal and trusting relationship with God. Witnessing these acts on the first hand or simply hearing about them would strengthen people's belief and commitment. Making the connection to the divine not so far away and unreachable.

After reading about Jesus' deeds, I found many similarities between his actions and those of the Hindu deity Krishna in the *Bhagavad Gita*. For example, Krishna emphasizes selfless action, devotion, and compassion as paths to liberation (*Bhagavad Gita* 2:47; 3:19; 12:2). This aligns with Jesus' deeds, such as healing the paralyzed man and forgiving his sins (*Mark* 2:1-12). Additionally, Krishna advises Arjuna to surrender to him completely and perform his duty without attachment (*Gita* 3:19). This aligns with Jesus' call for trust in divine intervention and performing acts of compassion without seeking personal glory.

Scholars like Francis X. Clooney have explored these parallels, arguing that theology is an interreligious discipline. Clooney suggests that thinkers across religions share similar theological questions and methods. By exploring these parallels, we can deepen our understanding of Christian thought through a cross-cultural perspective, highlighting universal themes of selfless action, divine trust, and inner purity (Clooney, 2001).

Jesus' teachings and actions challenged traditional norms, emphasizing boundless love, compassion and faith to salvation, in contrast to the Pharisees and Scribes. And by incorporating Krishna's deeds, we gain a broader, cross-cultural understanding of these themes. Ultimately, Jesus' mission centers on boundless love, encouraging followers to restore their faith in the divine.

(698 words)

Works Cited

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